

THE WAY OF THE WARRIOR

A Fate's Edge Expansion for Combat, Courage, and the Edge of the Blade

"Steel is a language. Learn to speak it, or learn to bleed."

COMPILED FROM THE NOTEBOOKS OF MASTER TARIAN IRONHAND

Fencing Master of the Iron Rose Academy, Silkstrand

A Letter from the Master

“You think the sword is the weapon? No. The weapon is the space between heartbeats. The sword is just the messenger.”

— *Master Tarian Ironhand, from a letter to a former student*

I have trained soldiers, duelists, palace guards, and gutter fighters. I have seen a Sekogo throw-knife unhorse a knight at forty paces. I have watched a Dhaharan elephant cavalry stampede shatter a shield wall that held for three hours. I have stood in the arena sand of Ecktoria while the crowd screamed for blood, and I have walked away clean.

This book is not a catalogue of techniques. You will not learn the perfect lunge or the unbreakable guard by reading. What you will learn is *how to think* when the steel sings.

The Six Roads are for witches and runekeepers. This is the Seventh Road: the road of the warrior. No patron, no symbol, no codex—only the edge, the will, and the breath you have left.

I have written these pages for three kinds of student:

The Soldier who wants to stand in the shield wall and not break.

The Duelist who wants to end a fight before it begins.

The Survivor who wants to walk away from places where others die.

Take what serves you. Leave the rest. And if you ever find yourself in Silkstrand, seek me out at the Iron Rose. The first lesson is free. The second costs a story.

— *Master Tarian Ironhand, Silkstrand, Year of the Broken Crown*

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Chapter 1

The Warrior's Path

“Every scar is a lesson. Some lessons are written in flesh. Some are written in the memories of the ones who watched you survive.”

— *Master Tarian*

To walk the Warrior's Path is to understand that violence is a *language*. It has grammar, syntax, and dialects. The Fhara lancer speaks in thunder. The Sidhi skirmisher speaks in whispers. The Ashaan charioteer speaks in patience. All are valid. All will kill you if you mispronounce.

This chapter draws from the great warrior traditions of Fate's Edge: the chariot warfare of Ashaan, the armored lancers of Oshiira, the throw-knife hunters of Sekogo, the cataphracts of Pereshi, the light cavalry of the Sidhi, the elephant riders of Dhahara, and the desert raiders of Fhara.

◆ Lore: The First Edge ◆

Old soldiers say the first weapon was not stone but a word. “Mine.” The second weapon was a broken branch. The third was the lie that you had already won. In the ruins of Old Aeler, archaeologists found a skeleton still gripping a bronze khopesh, its blade notched from parrying—not steel, but bone. The inscription nearby read: “*He held the ford for three bells. His name is lost. His edge is not.*” That is the warrior's true lineage: not victory, but the refusal to drop the line.

1.1 The Warrior's Attributes

A warrior's body is their first weapon. But the mind is the hand that wields it.

- **Body** – strength, endurance, the ability to deal and receive harm.
- **Wits** – timing, perception, the ability to read an opponent's intent.
- **Spirit** – courage, resolve, the will to stand when standing is foolish.
- **Presence** – command, intimidation, the ability to shape a battlefield with a word.

1.2 The Warrior's Talents

1.2.1 Foundation Talents (2-4 XP)

Disciplined Body (2 XP)

You may ignore 1 point of Fatigue from physical exertion once per scene.

Weapon Mastery (4 XP)

Choose a weapon category (swords, axes, spears, etc.). When using a weapon from that category, you gain +1 die to attack rolls and may re-roll one 1 on damage. You may take this talent multiple times for different categories.

Second Wind (2 XP)

Once per session, as an action, you may clear 2 Fatigue and remove one minor Condition (Dazed, Winded, etc.).

1.2.2 Advanced Talents (6-8 XP)

Weapon Mastery II — Flowing Strike (6 XP)

Requires Weapon Mastery.

When you successfully hit a target, you may immediately make a free repositioning move (up to Near distance) without provoking opportunity attacks. You may use this ability once per scene.

Disciplined Body II — Iron Resilience (6 XP)

Requires Disciplined Body.

You have two additional Harm boxes (for a total of 5). Additionally, the first time you would be reduced to 0 Harm in a scene, you may instead remain standing with 1 Harm and mark 2 Fatigue.

Battlefield Awareness (6 XP)

Requires Wits 3+.

At the start of any combat scene, you may ask the GM one tactical question: "Which enemy is most dangerous?", "Where is the best cover?", "What is the escape route?" The GM must answer truthfully.

Chapter 2

Martial Archetypes

“The tank is the anvil. The striker is the hammer. The ranger is the knife that finds the gap between ribs. Know which you are before the drum sounds.”

— *Master Tarian*

2.1 The Tank

The tank stands where others cannot. She absorbs harm, holds chokepoints, and forces enemies to waste their strength on her armored shell.

2.1.1 Core Talents

- *Disciplined Body* (2 XP)
- *Shield Bearer* (4 XP): When wielding a shield, you gain +1 Armor and may use the *Protect* action to interpose yourself between an ally and an attack, taking the harm yourself.
- *Disciplined Body II — Iron Resilience* (6 XP)

2.1.2 Signature Talent Chain — Sentinel

Sentinel — Stand Fast (4 XP)

You may use an action to adopt a stationary defensive stance. While in this stance, you cannot move, but enemies attacking you suffer –1 die, and any enemy that attempts to move past you must test Resolve (DV 3) or be stopped in their tracks. You may end the stance as a free action.

Sentinel II — Unmovable (8 XP)

Requires Sentinel — Stand Fast.

While in your defensive stance, you ignore the first shove, trip, or knockback attempt each round. Additionally,

allies within Near range gain +1 die to resist fear or compulsion effects.

Sentinel III — Shield of the Fallen (12 XP)

Requires Sentinel II.
Once per session, when an ally within Near range would be reduced to 0 Harm, you may instead take that harm yourself (reducing it by 2 before applying to yourself). After using this ability, you mark 1 Fatigue and cannot move for one full exchange.

2.1.3 Cultural Variant: Dhaharan Elephant Rider

The Dhaharan principalities field elephant cavalry that serve as mobile fortresses. A warrior who bonds with a war elephant gains the *Mahout's Authority* talent: while mounted, your mount gains +1 Armor and your melee reach extends to Near. Requires the *Sentinel* talent chain.

"The elephant does not charge. It walks. And everything in its path becomes mud." — *Rajah Anant, Dhaharan mahout*

◆ Voice from the Field: Rajah Anant, Dhaharan Mahout ◆

"You ask why I do not fear the arrows? The elephant's hide is thicker than any Eкторian armor. But the real shield is memory. This beast remembers the monsoon flood that drowned his mother. He remembers the taste of sugarcane from when he was a calf. And he remembers the first time he crushed a siege tower. Fear cannot reach a creature who has already survived the worst day of his life. That is what I learned from him: the past is a better shield than any steel."

2.2 The Striker

The striker deals harm. Fast, precise, and often fragile, the striker ends fights before they become wars.

2.2.1 Core Talents

- *Weapon Mastery* (4 XP)
- *Flurry* (4 XP): Once per scene, you may make two attacks against the same target as a single action. Resolve each attack separately. After using Flurry, you suffer –1 die on your next action.
- *Weapon Mastery II — Flowing Strike* (6 XP)

2.2.2 Signature Talent Chain — Bladestorm

Bladestorm — Whirlwind (4 XP)

When you are surrounded by two or more enemies in Close range, you may make a single attack roll against all of them simultaneously. Roll once; compare to each enemy's DV. You cannot use this ability more than once per scene.

Bladestorm II — Death's Draw (8 XP)

Requires Bladestorm — Whirlwind.

Once per session, when you reduce an enemy to 0 Harm, you may immediately make a free move (up to Near distance) and make one attack against a different enemy. This does not count as your action for the round.

2.2.3 Cultural Variant: Sekogo Throw-Knife Hunter

The Sekogo warriors of the southern jungles carry the *kpinga*—a multi-bladed throwing knife with a rotating motion that inflicts deep wounds. Their signature talent is *Whirling Steel*: when you throw a *kpinga*, it returns to your hand after striking (or missing) if you have a clear line of sight. This replaces *Flurry* in the talent chain.

"The kpinga does not fly. It dances. And the dance always ends with blood." — Mkara, Sekogo hunter

◆ Voice from the Field: Mkara, Sekogo Hunter ◆

"You westerners train to hold the line. We train to disappear. The jungle is not an obstacle—it is a collaborator. When I throw the *kpinga*, I am not aiming at your heart. I am asking the vines to pull your shield aside. I am asking the shadow to hide my second blade. And I am asking the mud to remember where you stepped. The dance ends when you stop guessing where I am."

2.3 The Ranger

The ranger fights at range, moves through difficult terrain, and lives by patience. They are the hunter, the scout, the one who sees the enemy before the enemy sees them.

2.3.1 Core Talents

- *Weapon Mastery (bows or thrown weapons)* (4 XP)
- *Keen Senses* (2 XP): +1 die to Perception rolls.
- *Heightened Senses* (3 XP): You cannot be surprised in natural terrain.

2.3.2 Signature Talent Chain — Pathfinder

Pathfinder — Trackless Step (4 XP)

You leave no trail when moving through natural terrain unless you choose to. Pursuers suffer –2 dice to track you.

Pathfinder II — Eagle Eye (6 XP)

Requires Pathfinder — Trackless Step.
When you make a ranged attack from a hidden position, treat your Position as one step higher (Desperate → Controlled, Controlled → Dominant). Additionally, you may ignore one level of range penalty (Near → Close, Far → Near).

Pathfinder III — The Patient Hunter (10 XP)

Requires Pathfinder II.
If you spend at least one scene observing a target (tracking them, watching their patterns), you gain +2 dice on your first attack against them and may choose to convert a hit into a non-lethal takedown (unconscious, pinned, disarmed) instead of dealing harm.

2.3.3 Cultural Variant: Ashaan Chariot Archer

The Ashaan horse-drawn chariot is a lightweight vehicle that carries a driver and a warrior. The chariot archer fires from a moving platform, using the vehicle’s speed to evade return fire. Their signature talent is *Chariot Volley*: when you fire from a chariot that has moved at least Near distance this round, you may make two attacks as a single action. This replaces *Eagle Eye* in the chain.

"The chariot is not a carriage. It is a falcon with wheels. Strike, wheel, strike again." — Seneny Khenemet, Ashaan chariot captain

◆ Voice from the Field: Seneny Khenemet, Ashaani Charioteer ◆

"A chariot is a lie we tell the wind. The horses are not pulling wood—they are pulling a promise to be somewhere else before the arrow lands. My driver and I have not spoken in ten years. We do not need to. When he leans left, I know the river is three hundred paces ahead. When he spits, I know the enemy has crested the ridge. The quiet between us is the loudest command on the field."

Chapter 3

Cultural Warriors

“The same cut that is honorable in one land is an insult in another.
Learn the customs of the blade before you learn its weight.”

— *Master Tarian*

3.1 Ashaan — Charioteers of the Twin Rivers

The chariot is the arm of Ashaani power. Lightweight, two-wheeled, crewed by a driver and a warrior, it moves like a striking cobra. Ashaani warriors train from youth in archery, and every noble owns a chariot.

◆ Lore of the Twin Rivers ◆

The oldest Ashaani military text, *The Book of the Yoke*, warns: “The chariot that charges before the driver has eaten is a chariot that will return empty.” This practical wisdom also applies to negotiations: never sign a contract hungry, never pursue a fleeing enemy without water in your belly, and always let the horses drink before the archer boasts.

3.1.1 Core Talents for Ashaani Warriors

- *Weapon Mastery (chariot archery)* (4 XP): When firing from a chariot, you ignore the first range penalty.
- *Chariot Driver* (4 XP): You may drive a chariot and fire a bow in the same action (one roll for both).
- *The Unblinking Eye* (6 XP): Ashaani archers are trained to hold their draw under fire. You may delay your shot for up to one full exchange without losing accuracy; if you release after a delay, your attack gains +1 die.

3.1.2 Signature Technique: Khopesh Hook

The *khopesh* is a sickle-sword with a curved blade, evolved from battle axes. The Ashaani warrior uses the hook to pull aside an enemy's shield before striking.

Khopesh Hook (6 XP)

When you attack with a khopesh, you may declare a hook attempt. Make a normal attack roll. On a hit, you may choose to forgo damage and instead disarm the target (they drop one held item) or pull them off balance (–1 die to their next action). You may use this ability once per scene.

"The khopesh is not a sword. It is a question. The hook asks: will you drop your shield or your life?" — Pharaoh's Guard inscription

3.2 Oshiira — Sahelian Lancers

The Sahelian grasslands breed fast horses and faster warriors. Oshiira cavalry wear quilted armor and iron helmets, carry lances, sabers, and sometimes horse-bows. They fight in loose formations, charging, wheeling, and charging again.

◆ Lore of the Sahel ◆

The Oshiira have a saying: “The horse that knows two masters is a dead horse.” In practice, this means a lancer must choose—before the charge—whether he fights for honor (hold the line) or for pay (break and reform). The best captains know how to switch masters mid-gallop. The worst die trying.

3.2.1 Core Talents for Oshiira Warriors

- *Weapon Mastery (lance or saber)* (4 XP)
- *Mounted Charger* (4 XP): When you attack from horseback after moving at least Near distance, your attack gains +2 dice.
- *Chainmail Shirt* (2 XP): You wear a light chainmail shirt; +1 Armor, but –1 die to Stealth.

3.2.2 Signature Techniques: The Lance and the Bow

Lance Couched (6 XP)

When you charge with a lance and hit, your target must test Body + Endurance (DV 4) or be knocked prone. If the target is prone, your next attack against them gains +1 die.

Horse Archery (8 XP)

You may fire a bow from horseback without penalty, even at a gallop. Additionally, when you make a ranged attack from horseback, you may move up to Near distance before or after the attack without provoking opportunity attacks.

"The horse is my legs. The lance is my arm. The enemy is my proof." — Farari Souleymane, Oshiira war captain

3.3 Sekogo — Jungle Throw-Knife Hunters

The Sekogo warriors of the southern jungles wield the *kpinga*, a multi-bladed throwing knife that spins through the air, striking with at least one blade. A Sekogo hunter carries three or four, hidden behind a shield, and throws them only after exhausting his spears.

3.3.1 Core Talents for Sekogo Warriors

- *Weapon Mastery (throwing knives)* (4 XP)
- *Keen Senses* (2 XP)
- *Poisoner* (4 XP): You can craft and apply poisons to your throwing knives. Crafting requires a Wits + Craft test (DV 3) and a downtime scene.

3.3.2 Signature Technique: The Spiral Throw

Spiral Throw (6 XP)

When you throw a *kpinga*, you may declare a spiral throw. The weapon spins in a wide arc, striking multiple targets in a Near zone. Make a single attack roll; compare it to the DV of every target in the zone. You may use this ability once per scene.

Court Metal (8 XP)

Your *kpinga* is of the highest quality, forged under a chieftain's patronage. You may throw a *kpinga* without penalty in melee range, and retrieving a thrown *kpinga* is a free action (you have trained to catch it by the handle). However, you must announce your throw loudly before releasing it, as is the custom of the jungle.

"I do not throw the kpinga. I send it to speak for me. When it returns, it brings the truth." — Avongara clan proverb

3.4 Pereshi — Cataphracts of the High Plateau

The Pereshi cataphract is a walking fortress. Rider and horse are both encased in scale or chain armor. Armed with the heavy *kontos* lance, sword, mace, and sometimes a horse-bow, the cataphract is designed to smash infantry lines and terrify lighter cavalry.

◆ Lore of the High Plateau ◆

Pereshi smiths say a cataphract's armor is forged in seven layers: iron for the enemy's sword, faith for the enemy's doubt, silence for the enemy's shouts, memory for the enemy's forgetting, salt for the enemy's thirst, wind for the enemy's arrows, and one secret layer known only to the wearer. The secret layer is usually a letter from home.

3.4.1 Core Talents for Pereshi Warriors

- *Weapon Mastery (lance or mace)* (4 XP)
- *Heavy Armor Training* (4 XP): You ignore the first –1 die penalty for wearing heavy armor.
- *Cataphract Charge* (6 XP): When you charge with a *kontos* lance, your attack ignores 1 point of Armor and, on a hit, the target must test Resolve (DV 4) or be Shaken (–1 die to all actions for one exchange).

3.4.2 Signature Techniques: The Armored Fence

Armored Fence (8 XP)

When you form a line with at least two other cataphracts, your unit gains +1 Armor and cannot be charged without the enemy first testing Resolve (DV 5). Breaking the formation costs 1 Fatigue.

Kontos Thrust (6 XP)

The *kontos* lance is held with two hands and braced against the horse's neck. You may use it one-handed while carrying a shield, but your attack suffers –1 die. If you use it two-handed, you gain +1 die and +1 Harm, but cannot use a shield.

"The cataphract does not fight. He arrives. And arrival is sufficient." — Shahanshah inscription

3.5 Sidhi — Light Skirmishers of the Broken Coast

The Sidhi ride fast, unarmored horses, controlling their mounts with a simple rope around the neck. They carry a handful of javelins, a short sword, and a round leather shield. Their tactic is simple: charge, throw javelins, wheel away, repeat.

◆ Lore of the Broken Coast ◆

Sidhi riders do not name their horses. They believe a name is a leash, and a leash is a promise to stay. Instead they whisper a color to the horse each morning: “blue” for rain, “red” for blood, “white” for salt, “black” for goodbye. A horse that dies in battle is not mourned—it is remembered by the color it carried.

3.5.1 Core Talents for Sidhi Warriors

- *Weapon Mastery (javelin or short sword)* (4 XP)
- *Light Cavalry* (4 XP): You may ride without saddle or bridle; your horse responds to knee pressure and spoken commands. When you make a Ride test, you gain +1 die.
- *Javelin Volley* (6 XP): You carry four javelins. As an action, you may throw two of them at the same target. Resolve each attack separately. After the volley, you are unarmed until you retrieve more javelins.

3.5.2 Signature Technique: Harassing Skirmish

Harassing Skirmish (8 XP)

When you throw a javelin and then move away, your target suffers –1 die to their next action (distracted by the near miss). You may use this ability once per round.

The Feigned Flight (6 XP)

You may pretend to retreat, luring an enemy into pursuit. Make a Deception test (DV 3). On a success, the enemy pursues, and on their next turn they must move toward you. On your following turn, you may turn and attack with +2 dice. This ability costs 1 Fatigue.

"We do not hold the line. We draw the line, and then we draw it somewhere else." — Sidhi cavalry captain

3.6 Dhahara — Elephant- Riders of the Monsoon Plains

The Dhaharan war elephant is a mobile fortress. The mahout sits on the elephant's neck, guiding it with voice and hook. From the howdah (a fortified platform on the elephant's back), archers and javelin-throwers rain death on enemies below.

3.6.1 Core Talents for Dhaharan Warriors

- *Weapon Mastery (composite bow or javelin)* (4 XP)
- *Mahout's Bond* (6 XP): You have bonded with a specific war elephant. While riding it, your melee reach extends to Near, and you may treat the elephant as having +1 Armor.
- *Elephant Charge* (8 XP): Your elephant may make a trample attack against all enemies in a Near zone. Each target must test Body + Athletics (DV 4) or take Harm 2 and be knocked prone. Using this ability costs 2 Fatigue for the elephant.

3.6.2 Signature Techniques: Howdah Archery

Howdah Archery (6 XP)

You may fire a bow or throw a javelin from the howdah without penalty, even while the elephant is moving. Additionally, you gain +1 Armor while in the howdah (cover).

Stampede (10 XP)

Once per session, you may send your elephant into a stampede. All enemies in a Large zone must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 5) or flee in panic. Those who fail also take Harm 1 (trampled). After the stampede, your elephant is Winded (−1 die on all actions for the rest of the scene).

"The elephant does not forget. It also does not forgive. That is why we ride them into battle." — Rajah inscription

3.7 Fhara — Desert Raiders of the Dune Sea

The Fhara Bedouin are masters of the lance and the saber. They ride swift horses, wear only light chain or leather, and rely on speed and surprise. Their lance is often a hollow bamboo tube tipped with iron; after the lance is spent, they draw their curved saber (seif).

◆ Lore of the Dune Sea ◆

Fhara poets recite the *Maqamat al-Furusiyya*, a cycle of verses about horses who outran death. One verse: “He rode a gray mare named Debt. She carried him through three wars. When he tried to pay her back with grain, she bit his sleeve and said, ‘You owe me a story, not oats.’” The Fhara believe a warrior’s true wealth is the number of enemies who remember his horse’s name.

3.7.1 Core Talents for Fhara Warriors

- *Weapon Mastery (lance or saber)* (4 XP)
- *Desert Rider* (4 XP): You ignore the first environmental penalty from heat or sand. Your horse also ignores the first penalty.
- *Furusiyya Training* (6 XP): You have trained in the full art of the horse warrior: lance, saber, bow, and horsemanship. You gain +1 die to all Ride tests and may re-roll one failed attack with a lance or saber per scene.

3.7.2 Signature Techniques: The Lance and the Saber

Lance Recover (6 XP)

After impaling an enemy with your lance, you may recover the weapon as a free action (you have trained to brace, strike, and withdraw in one motion). If you fail to recover, you must draw your saber.

Curved Blade (8 XP)

Your saber’s curved edge is designed for slashing while riding past. When you make a melee attack from horseback and continue moving, your attack gains +1 die and, on a hit, you may move an additional Near distance after the strike.

The Hollow Lance (10 XP)

Your lance is made of a hollow tube that whistles when thrown. Once per session, you may throw your lance as a ranged weapon (Near range). On a hit, the target is Shaken (–1 die to all actions) for one exchange, and the whistling sound panics nearby horses (they must test Resolve or flee).

"The lance is the question. The saber is the answer. The horse is the silence between them." — Fhara poet

Chapter 4

Runic Warrior

“Carve your vows into your flesh. Let your scars be your scripture.”

— *Master Tarian*

A **Runic Warrior** is a Runekeeper who writes their covenant in flesh, stone, or steel rather than ink and paper. Their Codex is not a book—it is a scarred hand, an engraved gorget, a sentient blade that remembers every oath they swore.

This is not a new class. You still track Obligation, invoke Rites, and serve a Patron. But your tools are different, your costs are visible, and your covenant is written on your body.

4.1 The Runic Codex

Choose one form:

Flesh Codex (Cannot be stolen)

Rites are tattooed, branded, or scarred onto your skin.

- **Advantage:** Cannot be confiscated. Always accessible. No action to retrieve.
- **Risk:** Visible to everyone. Damage to your skin may damage the Codex. Some cultures fear flesh-writing.

Stone Codex (Durable, can be lost)

Rites are carved, etched, or engraved onto a physical object—a gorget, a shield, a staff, a gauntlet.

- **Advantage:** Can serve as armour or weapon. Durable. May grant social advantage.
- **Risk:** Can be stolen, confiscated, or broken.

Steel Codex (Sentient, rare)

Rites are engraved on a sentient weapon or object that speaks and remembers.

- **Advantage:** Functions as both Codex and Thiasos. Counts as a witness for all Rites. Can offer counsel.
- **Risk:** Has its own personality and opinions. Cannot be easily replaced. Attracts attention.

Your Codex sees every Rite you invoke. It counts as a **witness** for any Rite that requires one, improving Position or reducing DV.

4.2 Obligation as Physical Scar

When you mark Obligation, the cost is **visible**:

- **Minor (1-2 segments):** A small scar, a bruise that doesn't fade, an aching tooth.
- **Moderate (3-4 segments):** A visible scar on the face or hands, a limp, a smouldering brand.
- **Significant (5-6 segments):** A missing finger, a clouded eye, bark-like skin.
- **Critical (7+ segments):** A numb limb, a face that reflections avoid, a forgotten name.

A scar is not a punishment. It is a receipt. Touch a scar to recall the Rite that caused it; an NPC may recognise it as the mark of a specific Patron.

4.3 The Thiasos as Ally

Your Thiasos may be:

Living Thiasos (Creature)

A warhorse, spirit-hound, wolf-ancestor, fungal familiar, or hollowed bird.

- **Cap:** 2–5
- **Harm:** Cap + 2
- **Independent action:** Once per scene, on your turn
- **Witness:** Always counts for Rites
- **Shared Burden (talent):** Transfer Fatigue to your Thiasos (it becomes Winded)

Sentient Thiasos (Object) — Optional

A weapon, shield, or tool that speaks and remembers. Cannot act independently.

- **Witness:** Always counts
- **Communication:** Speaks aloud
- **Codex:** Can serve as both Thiasos and Codex
- **Cannot accept Shared Burden**

4.4 Core Talents

Foundation Talents (2-4 XP)

- **Flesh Codex (2 XP)** — *Body 3+*. Rites tattooed on body; cannot be stolen.
- **Living Thiasos (3 XP)** — *A living Thiasos*. Your Thiasos gains +1 Cap and may act independently once per scene.
- **Scarred Resilience (3 XP)** — *Body 2+*. Once per scene, ignore 1 Fatigue from physical exertion.
- **Oath-Bound (4 XP)** — *A sworn oath*. Once per session, reroll a failed Body roll when serving a sworn oath.
- **Talking Weapon (2 XP)** — *Sentient Thiasos*. Your Thiasos speaks aloud and counts as a witness.

Advanced Talents (6-8 XP)

- **Engraved Defence (6 XP)** — *Physical Codex*. Your Codex grants +1 Armour. You may mark 1 Obligation to reduce incoming Harm by 1.
- **Shared Burden (6 XP)** — *Living Thiasos*. Transfer 1 Fatigue to your Thiasos; it becomes Winded (-1 die) for the scene.
- **Witnessed Scar (8 XP)** — *Three permanent Obligation scars*. Once per session, touch a scar and gain +1 die on any roll tied to that event.
- **Iron Resolve (7 XP)** — *Body 3+, resilience talent*. When reduced to 0 Harm, remain standing with 1 Harm and mark 2 Fatigue.

Prestige Talents (10-12 XP)

- **The Unbroken Vow (10 XP)** — *Kept a sworn oath for one year*. When you swear an oath before a witness, gain +2 dice to all actions serving it.
- **Avatar of the Codex (12 XP)** — *Tier III+, physical Codex*. Once per session, become the embodiment of your Codex: Body +2, your Thiasos fights as a second combatant. Mark 2 Fatigue and 1 Obligation after.

- **The Scar That Remembers (11 XP)** — *Witnessed Scar, Tier III+*. Once per session, touch a scar and speak a sentence about the event that caused it. That sentence is considered witnessed truth in any court.

4.5 Sample Rites

Low Rites (4-5 XP)

- **Rite of the Kindled Blade (Oath of Flame & Light) — 4 XP**. Your weapon ignites with radiant light. For one scene, melee attacks deal +1 Harm against undead and oath-breakers.
- **Rite of the Blood Offering (Grimmir) — 4 XP**. Gain +1 die to Survival and Stealth in natural terrain for one scene.
- **Rite of the Unlit Candle (Ikasha) — 4 XP**. Gain +1 die to a single Stealth or Subterfuge roll; on success, declare one minor detail “forgotten” by any observer.
- **Rite of the Shared Bowl (Oath of Mercy & Grace) — 4 XP**. You and a touched ally each clear 1 Fatigue.

Standard Rites (7-9 XP)

- **Rite of the Unbroken Vow (Oath of Flame & Light) — 7 XP**. Swear an oath before a flame and a witness; gain +1 Armour. Allies who hear the oath gain +1 die to actions serving it.
- **Rite of the Sealed Threshold (The Sealed Gate) — 7 XP**. Mark a doorway as sealed. Unauthorised crossing tests Resolve (DV 3) or suffers a Position penalty.
- **Rite of the Spinner’s Debt (Inaea) — 9 XP**. Offer a willing creature a boon (clear 1 Fatigue or +1 die). They accept a Promise Clock [4] named “Debt to the Web”.

High Rites (12-14 XP)

- **Rite of the Dawnfire Covenant (Oath of Flame & Light) — 12 XP**. Consecrate a zone; allies gain +1 die to resist fear. Undead or oath-breaker enemies suffer -1 die.
- **Rite of the Umbral Dream (Ikasha) — 14 XP**. Become intangible to mundane harm for one scene, or bypass a major obstacle as if a secret way had always been there.
- **Rite of the Eternal Cycle (Carrion-King) — 14 XP**. Destroy one major asset, enemy, or obstacle, and create something new of equal value. Player and GM collaborate on the transformation.

4.6 Runic Warrior Builds by Tradition

4.6.1 The War-Priest of Ashaan (Mykkiel / Inquisitor Prime)

The Ashaani war-priest serves the law of the Twin Rivers. He is both judge and executioner, carrying a *khopesh* that has witnessed a hundred oaths. His Thiasos is often a hound of ash and seal-wax, and his Codex is a bronze plague bound to his shield.

Core Talents (Existing)

- *Disciplined Body* (2 XP)
- *Shield Bearer* (4 XP)
- *Rites of Mykkiel or Inquisitor Prime*

Signature Talent Chain — Oath of the Khopesh

Oath of the Khopesh — Hook and Cut (6 XP)

When you hit with your khopesh, you may choose to hook the target instead of dealing harm. The target is pulled off balance; they suffer –1 die to their next action. You may use this ability once per scene.

4.6.2 The Gilded Lancers of Oshiira (The Traveler / The Sealed Gate)

The Oshiira Gilded Lancers are professional cavalymen who have sworn to protect the trade routes of the Sahel. Their Codex is a saddlebag of route charts; their Thiasos is a spirit horse that leaves no tracks.

Core Talents (Existing)

- *Weapon Mastery (lance)* (4 XP)
- *Mounted Charger* (4 XP)
- *Rites of the Traveler*

Signature Talent Chain — Way of the Horse

Way of the Horse — Ride the Wind (6 XP)

Your Thiasos grants your mount +1 Speed and the ability to ignore difficult terrain for one scene. You mark 1 Obligation each time you use this ability.

4.6.3 The Jungle Wardens of Sekogo (The Carrion-King / Isoka)

The Sekogo jungle warden sheds his old skin with each battle, transforming from hunter to hunted to hunter again. His Codex is a belt of throw-knives; his Thiasos is a python that watches from the trees.

Core Talents (Existing)

- *Weapon Mastery (throwing knives)* (4 XP)
- *Poisoner* (4 XP)
- *Rites of the Carrion-King or Isoka*

Signature Talent Chain — The Shed Skin**The Shed Skin — Venomous Strike (6 XP)**

When you throw a kpinga, you may choose to apply a poison (if you have one) as a free action. The poison takes effect on a hit, even if the target is armored.

4.6.4 The Cataphract of Pereshi (Mykkiel / The Witness)

The Pereshi cataphract is a knight of the high plateau, sworn to uphold the laws of the ancient empire. His Codex is a lance; his Thiasos is a war-horse clad in scale armor.

Core Talents (Existing)

- *Heavy Armor Training* (4 XP)
- *Cataphract Charge* (6 XP)
- *Rites of Mykkiel or The Witness*

Signature Talent Chain — The Kontos**The Kontos — Lance of Judgment (8 XP)**

When you charge with your kontos lance, your attack ignores 1 point of Armor and, on a hit, the target must test Resolve (DV 4) or be Shaken. You may spend 1 Obligation to increase the DV to 5.

4.6.5 The Light Riders of Sidhi (Aveh / Ikasha)

The Sidhi light rider has no fixed patron—she answers only to the wind and her own hunger. Her Codex is a handful of javelins; her Thiasos is a horse that has never felt a bridle.

Core Talents (Existing)

- *Light Cavalry* (4 XP)
- *Harassing Skirmish* (8 XP)
- *Rites of Aveh or Ikasha*

Signature Talent Chain — The Feigned Flight

The Feigned Flight — Dust and Smoke (6 XP)

When you fake a retreat, you may throw a javelin behind you as a free action. The attack is made at –1 die, but if it hits, the enemy is Shaken (confused by your treachery).

4.6.6 The Elephant-Rider of Dhahara (Grimmir / Raéyn)

The Dhaharan elephant-rider serves the monsoon and the plain. His Codex is a howdah; his Thiasos is the elephant itself, a living mountain of memory and rage.

Core Talents (Existing)

- *Mahout's Bond* (6 XP)
- *Elephant Charge* (8 XP)
- *Rites of Grimmir or Raéyn*

Signature Talent Chain — The Howdah

The Howdah — Archer's Nest (6 XP)

While in the howdah, you gain +1 Armor (cover) and may fire a bow without penalty, even while the elephant is moving. You may spend 1 Obligation to extend this protection to one other archer in the howdah.

4.6.7 The Desert Raider of Fhara (Aveh / The Traveler)

The Fhara desert raider lives by the code of *furusiyya*: horsemanship, chivalry, and the mutual dependence of man and horse. His Codex is a saddle; his Thiasos is a falcon that returns after each flight.

Core Talents (Existing)

- *Furusiyya Training* (6 XP)
- *Lance Recover* (6 XP)
- *Rites of Aveh or the Traveler*

Signature Talent Chain — The Falcon's Return

The Falcon's Return — Lance Recall (6 XP)

After throwing your hollow lance, you may whistle; the lance returns to your saddle as a free action. You may use this ability once per scene.

4.7 Sample Build — Tier I Dawn Warrior (36XP)

Concept: A crusader who carries vows in steel and fire.

Attributes:

- Body 3 (9 XP)
- Spirit 2 (6 XP)
- Presence 2 (6 XP)
- Wits 1 (3 XP)

Total: 24 XP

Skills:

- Melee 2 (4 XP)
- Command 1 (2 XP)
- Athletics 1 (2 XP)

Total: 8 XP

Talents:

- Flesh Codex (2 XP)
- Oath-Bound (4 XP)
- Scarred Resilience (3 XP)

Total: 9 XP

Rites:

- Rite of the Kindled Blade (4 XP)

Gear: Engraved gauntlet (Codex), longsword, chainmail shirt.

Obligation Capacity: Spirit 2 + Presence 2 = 4.

Chapter 5

Monks and Ascetics

“The fist is a weapon. The open hand is a promise. Learn both before you need either.”

— *Master Tarian*

Monks do not wear armour. They do not carry shields. They walk the world with nothing but their bodies and their breath—and they are among the deadliest fighters alive. This chapter summarises the *Complete Guide to Monks*, giving you the core tools to build an Unstruck Bell monk in minutes.

5.1 The Unstruck Bell Philosophy

A monk’s greatest strength is not the clenched fist but the open hand. Power lies in the pause before the strike. The world runs on breath, balance, and the careful stillness between action and consequence.

- **The Coin That Does Not Move:** Never resist what cannot be stopped. Yield, and the enemy’s own force becomes their downfall.
- **The Witness Who Breathes:** Stillness is the greatest disguise. Be unremarkable.
- **The Debt That Is Never Incurred:** When you do not strike, you create no debt. Victory is a chain. The open hand offers nothing, and so nothing can be taken from it.

5.2 Meditation Mini-Game

To find the still point, you need stillness, time, and intent. The four breaths:

1. **The Entering Breath:** Inhale the world’s noise, threat, opportunity.
2. **The Holding Breath:** The pause where decisions are made.
3. **The Releasing Breath:** The exhale that becomes action.
4. **The Empty Breath:** The space after the exhale. Act from here to become invisible to predictions.

Meditation Procedure

1. **Settle the Body (Wits + Medicine, DV 2):** On a hit, gain +1 die to the Meditation roll.
2. **Settle the Breath (Spirit + Meditation skill, DV 3):** On a hit, enter a light meditative state.
3. **The Still Point (Spirit + Resolve, DV 3 for clarity, DV 4 for healing, DV 5 for transcendence):** Achieve your intent.

Meditation Benefits

- **Healing:** Clear 1 Fatigue and remove one minor Condition (Fear, Shaken, Guilty) with a test.
- **Clarity:** Gain +1 die to your next Wits-based roll.
- **Transcendent:** Once per session, reroll any single failed roll; the GM gains 1 Story Beat.

5.3 Core Monk Talents

Unarmed Combatant (4 XP)

Your unarmed strikes deal Harm 1 and may be used to grapple, trip, or pin. You gain +1 die to grapple attempts.

Disciplined Body (2 XP)

You may ignore 1 point of Fatigue from physical exertion once per scene.

Flurry of Blows (6 XP)

Once per scene, you may make three unarmed attacks against a single target as one action. Roll each separately. After using Flurry of Blows, you suffer –1 die to defence for one exchange.

Still Point (2 XP)

When you do not move during your turn, gain +1 die to your next defence roll. This benefit lasts until you move or take an aggressive action.

Monk's Breath (2 XP)

Once per session, you may clear 1 Fatigue by meditating for one minute uninterrupted. No roll required.

5.4 Monastic Traditions

Choose a tradition that defines your martial and philosophical lineage.

5.4.1 Way of the Unstruck Bell (Ikasha – Shadow)

You read the gaps in perception, become forgettable, and move through shadows.

Basic Technique – Shadow Meld (6 XP)

Prerequisite: Stealth 2+. Once per session, step into any shadow larger than yourself and emerge from another shadow within Near range. Mark 1 Fatigue.

Advanced Technique – The Unobserved (8 XP)

Prerequisite: Tier II, Stealth 3+. When you are Hidden, social Story Beats cannot frame you for a crime you did not commit. Witnesses suffer –2 dice to recall your face.

5.4.2 Way of the Iron Vow (Mykkiel / Oath of Flame – Law)

Your body is a temple; your fist is a gavel. Swear binding oaths that grant power in exchange for restriction.

Basic Technique – Sworn Defender (6 XP)

Prerequisite: Body 3+. When you take the Defend action, an adjacent ally also gains +1 Armour until your next turn.

Advanced Technique – Unyielding Vow (8 XP)

Prerequisite: Tier II, Spirit 3+. Swear a vow before a witness. While actively working toward it, ignore the first point of Fatigue each scene from exhaustion, fear, or despair.

5.4.3 Way of the Endless Cup (Thrysos – Drunken Master)

Stagger and stumble to become impossible to anticipate. Every spill is a trip, every belch a battle cry.

Basic Technique – Stagger Step (4 XP)

Prerequisite: Body 3+. When an enemy misses you with a melee attack, move one range band without provoking opportunity attacks. Mark 1 Fatigue (once per round).

Advanced Technique – Drunken Fist (6 XP)

Prerequisite: Body 3+, Spirit 2+. Your unarmed strikes gain +1 die and ignore the first point of Armour when you are at Fatigue 2 or more.

5.5 Cultural Variants

5.5.1 Ashaan Stick Dancer (Tahtib)

Tahtib – Dance of Sticks (6 XP)

When you wield a long stick or staff, you gain +1 die to Parry and may make a free trip attempt after a successful parry. Enemies who watch you fight suffer –1 die to attack you.

5.5.2 Dhaharan Kalaripayattu

Kalaripayattu – Body as Serpent (6 XP)

Escape grapples as a free action (once per round). On a critical hit with an unarmed strike, impose a Condition (Blinded, Muted, Lamed) for one exchange.

5.5.3 Sidhi Knife Dancer

Knife Dance – Twin Blades (6 XP)

When you wield two khanjar knives, make two attacks as a single action against two different targets within Close range. Once per scene.

◆ Voice from the Monastery: Sister Ashwati, Sidhi Knife Dancer ◆

“My first master told me: ‘You are not learning to kill. You are learning to stop being afraid of the gap between your ribs.’ Every dance is a conversation with that gap. The left knife says ‘come closer.’ The right knife says ‘never mind.’ The spiral says ‘I am already behind you.’ When the crowd watches, they see violence. When I dance, I see geometry that breathes.”

5.6 Quick Build: Unstruck Bell Monk (Tier I, 36XP)

Concept: A silent shadow who strikes from darkness and vanishes.

Attributes:

- Body 3 (9 XP)
- Wits 3 (9 XP)
- Spirit 2 (6 XP)
- Presence 1 (3 XP)

Total: 27 XP

Skills:

- Stealth 2 (4 XP)
- Melee 1 (2 XP)
- Meditation 1 (2 XP)

Total: 8 XP

Talents:

- Unarmed Combatant (4 XP)
- Disciplined Body (2 XP)
- Still Point (2 XP)
- Monk's Breath (2 XP)

Tradition: Way of the Unstruck Bell (add Shadow Meld later).

Flavour: Your knuckles are calloused, your eyes are calm, and your shadow sometimes moves a heartbeat after you do.

The Breath Scar: Every monk who walks the Unstruck path accepts a permanent Breath Scar—you can never again be surprised, but neither can you ever truly rest.

Chapter 6

Shadow Warriors

“The best fight is the one the enemy never knows happened. The second-best is the one they survive to regret.”

— *Master Tarian*

Shadow warriors are martial arts who prefer stealth, misdirection, and the sudden strike. They are not rogues—they do not pick pockets or climb walls (though they can). They are *killers* who hide in plain sight.

6.0.1 The Ashaani Assassin (Veiled Hunter)

Ashaani assassins are trained in the art of the hidden blade. They strike from crowds, from shadows, from the moment when the victim blinks.

6.0.2 Core Talents

- *Stealth* (existing)
- *Weapon Mastery (hidden blade or dagger)* (4 XP)
- *Poisoner* (4 XP)

6.0.3 Signature Technique: The Veiled Strike

Veiled Strike (8 XP)

When you attack from a hidden position or from a crowd, your target suffers –1 die to defend (they do not see the threat until it is too late). Additionally, if you attack with a poisoned blade, the poison’s DV is reduced by 1 (to a minimum of 1).

6.0.4 The Sekogo Ambusher

The jungles of Sekogo are dark and dense. Sekogo warriors use the terrain to vanish after each thrown knife, reappearing elsewhere.

6.0.5 Core Talents

- *Stealth* (existing)
- *Weapon Mastery (throwing knives)* (4 XP)
- *Keen Senses* (2 XP)

6.0.6 Signature Technique: Vanishing Throw

Vanishing Throw (8 XP)

After throwing a kpinga, you may immediately move up to Near distance and make a Stealth test (DV 4). On a success, you become Hidden. If you were already Hidden, your next thrown attack gains +1 die.

Chapter 7

Encounter Tactics

“A fool learns from his own scars. A wise warrior learns from the scars of others. A genius never gets scarred at all.”

— *Master Tarian*

7.1 Positioning and Terrain

- **High Ground:** Gain +1 die to ranged attacks and +1 Position when defending against melee.
- **Chokepoints:** A doorway or bridge turns a horde into a queue. Tanks can hold a chokepoint while strikers attack from behind.
- **Cover:** A low wall or a wagon provides Partial Cover (+1 Armor), Total Cover (cannot be targeted). Destroying cover is a valid tactic.
- **Difficult Terrain:** Mud, rubble, or shallow water halves movement. Ranged attackers thrive here; melee fighters suffer.

7.2 Action Economy

The side that takes more actions wins. Use these principles:

- **Teamwork:** Use the *Aid* action to give an ally +1 die. Two characters aiding a striker can turn a miss into a crit.
- **Interrupts:** Talents like *Wound-Drinker* or *The Replacement* allow actions outside your turn. These are gold.
- **Use Boons:** Boons can be spent to improve Position or re-roll failures. Do not hoard them.

7.3 Non-Combat Tactics

The best fight is the one you avoid. Use these approaches:

- **Intimidation:** After a display of violence (a kill, a shattered weapon), make a Presence + Command test. On success, remaining enemies may flee or surrender.
- **Deception:** A false flag (dressing as the enemy) can let you walk through a camp. Requires a Deception test and a plausible story.
- **Parley:** Even in combat, a shouted offer of mercy can stop a fight. The GM may allow a Presence + Sway test as a free action.
- **Environmental Manipulation:** Cut the rope holding the chandelier. Set fire to the grain store. Collapse the tunnel. Creativity trumps stats.

♦ Mercenary Wisdom: The Black Banners ♦

The Black Banners teach a simple rule: “*Camp before clash.*” A battle is the interest on debts a captain accrued in camp: food, route, weather, rumor. If those sums are wrong, steel won’t save you. Before you draw your sword, count the paychest, the latrine trench, the chaplain’s bell. If any of those is empty, negotiate. A good mercenary wins more wars with a full belly than a sharp edge.

♦ Table Tactics: The Seven Bells of Combat ♦

A quick reference for players and GMs to keep combat flowing:

1. **State Intent:** “I want to flank the spearman.”
2. **Assess Risk:** The GM sets Position (Controlled/Dominant/Desperate).
3. **Declare Action:** Roll dice.
4. **Spend Boons:** Before or after the roll.
5. **Resolve Effect:** Apply harm, Conditions, or narrative changes.
6. **Spend SB:** GM may introduce complications (reinforcements, collapsing floor).
7. **Pivot to Next Player:** Keep the rhythm short. Combat should feel urgent.

Chapter 8

Arms and Armor

“The sword is a lie. What matters is the hand that holds it. But a good lie is easier to sell.”

— *Master Tarian*

8.1 Weapon Tags (Reminder)

- **ACCURATE:** +1 die to attack rolls.
- **Armor Piercing:** Ignore 1 point of Armor.
- **Brutal:** On a critical hit, add +1 Harm.
- **Defensive:** +1 die to Parry actions.
- **Heavy:** Two-handed; cannot be used with a shield.
- **Light:** May be dual-wielded.
- **Reach:** Can attack from Near range without closing.
- **Thrown:** May be used as a ranged weapon (Near).

8.2 Cultural Weapons with Unique Mechanics

8.2.1 Khopesh (Ashaan)

Khopesh

Type: Light (one-handed).

Tags: Accurate, Hook (see Khopesh Hook talent).

Damage: Harm 1 (slashing).

Special: The khopesh can be used to hook shields and weapons; see the Khopesh Hook talent.

8.2.2 Kpinga (Sekogo)

Kpinga (Throwing Knife)

Type: Light (thrown).

Tags: Thrown, Accurate, Brutal.

Damage: Harm 1 (piercing).

Special: A Sekogo warrior carries three or four kpinga. When thrown, the knife spins; if it hits, it deals +1 Harm (Brutal). A warrior must announce the throw loudly before releasing it (Court Metal custom).

8.2.3 Kontos Lance (Pereshi)

Kontos Lance

Type: Heavy (two-handed).

Tags: Armor Piercing, Reach, Charge (when used from horseback after moving, +1 die).

Damage: Harm 2 (piercing).

Special: The kontos can be used one-handed while carrying a shield, but the attack suffers –1 die.

8.2.4 Saber (Seif) (Fhara)

Seif (Saber)

Type: Light (one-handed).

Tags: Curved Blade (see Curved Blade talent).

Damage: Harm 1 (slashing).

Special: The curved blade is designed for slashing while riding past. See the Curved Blade talent.

8.2.5 Javelin (Sidhi)

Javelin

Type: Light (thrown or melee).

Tags: Thrown, Accurate.

Damage: Harm 1 (piercing).

Special: A Sidhi warrior carries four javelins. The Javelin Volley talent allows two to be thrown as a single action.

8.2.6 War Elephant (Dhahara)

War Elephant (Mount)

Type: Heavy (mount).

Tags: Armored, Trample, Fear.

Damage: Trample deals Harm 2 and knocks prone.

Special: Requires the Mahout's Bond talent. The elephant has its own Harm track (4) and Armor (2). It can be targeted separately from the mahout.

Chapter 9

Last Words from the Master

“Put down the book. Pick up the sword. The ink will dry. The steel will not.”

— *Master Tarian*

I have taught you what I can. The rest you must learn in the dust, the sand, the blood of the arena and the mud of the battlefield. Do not fear the edge—it is only the edge. What lies beyond is what you make of it.

If you find yourself in Silkstrand, seek me out. The gate to the Iron Rose is always open. The tea is always hot. The practice ring is always waiting.

And if I am not there, do not mourn. I have likely gone to find a student who needs me more.

— *Master Tarian Ironhand*

Chapter 10

Voices from the Edge

“Every warrior carries a different song. This is what they sing when they think no one is listening.”

— *Master Tarian*

Ykrul Scout, Tashfin of the Salt Flats “The Ykrul do not fight like your banner companies. We do not form lines. We do not charge. We watch. We wait. And then we make the ground remember what it forgot—that a dry riverbed is a highway, that a sand dune is a wall, that a star you cannot see is a dead man’s direction. My weapon is not my bow. It is the two days I spent learning your camp’s latrine schedule.”

Vilikari Night-Ferry Captain, Sanna Breeze-Name “You think ferries are for passengers? No. Ferries are for *timing*. A battle is a river: it flows one way until a single boat crosses at the wrong hour. Then the whole current changes. I have moved false orders, stolen paychests, and once—only once—a bride who was also a siege weapon. The Vilikari do not fight. We *arrange*.”

Ecktorian Centurion, Varinus the Scarred “The empire teaches us to hold the line. But the empire has never stood in the mud at Third Ford, watching the Dhaharan elephants sway like hills. That day, I learned the truth: a line is only as strong as the two people on either side of you. If they are afraid, you are afraid. If they run, you are dead. The secret is not courage. The secret is *choosing* to stand because you know your neighbor will, too.”

Lethai Hedge-Knight, Dame Xara of the Thorn “The Lethai do not dream of glory. We dream of repair. A broken wall, a burned mill, a child who cannot find her father. War is not a story—it is a debt. Every sword drawn must be repaid in stone, in seed, in silence. I carry a codex of hedges. Not to fight. To remember what I am fighting *for*.”

Bannerless One (anonymous) “The colors do not matter. The contract does not matter. What matters is the moment when the paychest is opened and every soldier inhales at the same time. That breath is the real oath. Not to a captain, not to a crown. To each other. ‘We will eat. We will walk. We will bury our

dead.’ Anyone who forgets that breath—I visit them at night. I do not carry a blade. I carry a mirror.”

Appendix A

The Black River at Dawn — A Runic Warrior's Tale

Roran did not sleep the night after the trial.

He sat on the cold stone bench of the Queen's garrison, the silver gauntlet heavy on his left hand, the locket warm against his palm on the right.

The gauntlet still smelled of the forge where it had been shaped—hammer strikes, the hiss of cooled steel, the ledger-books that recorded every blade, every horse, every ounce of grain as if they were the only things that gave a life meaning. The locket was soft, its surface worn smooth by years of being pressed against a mother's chest.

He had not opened it. He could not.

Whatever lay inside—a portrait, a lock of hair, a written name—would be the first proof that his mother had existed outside the cold arithmetic of his father's ledgers. Outside the columns of debts and dues.

He was afraid.

Not of the locket's contents. Of what it would cost him to keep it.

At the third bell, the garrison's watch changed. The corridors fell quiet. He rose, the gauntlet clinking faintly against the stone.

He moved through the sleeping city. His boots were silent on cobblestones that had once echoed with the march of soldiers. He passed the Silent Stair, where the wind whistled through broken stones like a lament. He passed the chapel where Alain the Cantor, voice raw from years of singing the *Planctus Armatus*, dreamed of feathers and forgotten songs.

The gates stood open. The war was over. The peace was young. The watch, trained for vigilance, had learned to sleep again.

The Black River lay ahead—a slow, dark ribbon drinking the first grey light of dawn.

He knelt at the bank. Cold water seeped through his breeches. The air smelled of iron and wet stone, of rain that had fallen days ago and would fall again.

He lifted the locket to his chest. Felt his own heartbeat against its cool metal.

He opened it.

Inside was not a portrait. It was a braid. A single, thin braid of auburn hair, tied with a scrap of red thread.

The braid was warm.

He pressed it to his lips. Closed his eyes. Listened.

Silence.

And then—

“Aldric.”

The voice came from the water. Or from the mist. Or from the hollow of his own chest. It was not his mother’s voice alone.

He looked up.

She stood on the far bank. Young. Younger than him. Younger than Eleanor. The age she had been when the birthing fever took her. Her hair fell loose, auburn and unbound. Her face held no sorrow—only a quiet certainty. A red blanket draped over her shoulders like a cloak.

“Mother,” he said.

She smiled.

“You have carried the weight long enough. The locket was never meant to be a burden. It was meant to be a bridge.”

She stepped toward the water’s edge. The river did not part. It simply accepted her. She stood on the surface as if the current had always been solid beneath her feet.

“Lay it at the bank. Tie it with the thread. Let the water carry it where it needs to go.”

“Where?”

“To her. To Bryn. She kept it for forty years. She never asked for thanks. But she deserves to know it reached you.”

He felt the old name strike him like a blow.

“That name forsook me. I am Roran now. That is the name I chose when I left the ledger behind.”

Her eyes softened. Not with disappointment. With understanding.

“Then let the river carry what you are ready to release. Not the name you were given. The weight you have carried because of it.”

He untied the braid. Felt the silk of the hair slip through his fingers. Took the red thread and wound it three times around the locket.

The first turn: the way the Cord had taught him to bind a promise.

The second turn: the way Bryn had shown Margot how to tie a knot that would hold.

The third turn: the way Margot had intended to teach her children—a lesson that ended with her own silence before she could pass it on.

He placed the locket on the muddy bank. The water lapped at its edge, testing.

“You have to let go,” his mother said.

“I have let go of everything.”

“Not everything. Not yet.”

He closed his eyes.

He opened his hand.

The water rose—not in a flood, but in a gentle lift, as if the river itself were a hand taking the locket from his grasp. It slipped beneath the surface with a soft, almost inaudible sigh.

When he looked up, she was gone.

But the mist had thinned. The first true light of dawn spilled over the eastern hills. The Black River ran clear and cold, carrying nothing but light.

He walked back to the garrison. He did not look back. He did not need to.

The gauntlet on his left hand, which had felt like ice when he first rose, now radiated a quiet warmth.

— *The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.*

Appendix B

Quick Reference: Martial Talents by Tier

Tier	Talent	Effect
Foundation (2-4 XP)	Disciplined Body	Ignore 1 Fatigue/scene.
	Weapon Mastery	+1 die with chosen weapon.
	Second Wind	Clear 2 Fatigue, remove Condition.
	Shield Bearer	+1 Armor when using shield; Protect action.
	Unarmed Combatant	Unarmed strikes Harm 1; grapple bonus.
Advanced (6-8 XP)	Weapon Mastery II — Flowing Strike	Free reposition after hit.
	Disciplined Body II — Iron Resilience	+2 Harm boxes; survive 0 Harm once.
	Battlefield Awareness	Ask one tactical question before combat.
	Flurry	Two attacks in one action (once/scene).
	Pathfinder — Trackless Step	Leave no trail in natural terrain.
	Khopesh Hook	Disarm or off-balance with khopesh.
	Harassing Skirmish	Javelin throw and move imposes –1 die.
Signature (10-12 XP)	Kontos Thrust	Two-handed lance use: +1 die, +1 Harm.
	Sentinel III — Shield of the Fallen	Take harm for an ally.
	Spiral Throw (Sekogo)	Throw kpinga hits all in a zone.
	Stampede (Dhahara)	Elephant forces panic in enemies.
	Cataphract Charge	Lance ignores armor, shakes foes.
	Veiled Strike (Ashaan)	Hidden attack ignores defense.